Problem and Solution Statement

Team: void

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The Problem

Public procurement is a cornerstone of governance, accounting for roughly 15% of global GDP. However, municipal procurement offices face a severe administrative bottleneck: they are routinely overwhelmed by high volumes of multi-vendor quote submissions, complex compliance checklists, and strict transparency mandates. In practice, public procurement officers must manually review competing bids, verify historical pricing benchmarks, screen vendors against exclusion lists, and watch out for hidden patterns of bid-rigging or collusion (such as shared addresses or phone numbers).

This manual review process is error-prone, slow, and leaves public funds vulnerable to inflated pricing, favoritism, and vendor fraud. Furthermore, citizens and oversight bodies rarely have access to clear, easily understandable explanations of why a particular vendor was chosen or how public money was spent. The core tension lies between maintaining speed in public operations and enforcing rigorous, audit-ready transparency and fraud prevention.

The Solution: ClearBid

To solve this, we developed **ClearBid**, an agentic AI-powered public procurement platform built to ensure every public purchase is fairly priced, thoroughly vetted, and fully transparent. ClearBid bridges the gap between automated risk screening and human accountability through an intelligent workflow:

- **Intelligent Multi-Quote Review Agent:** Built and orchestrated via IBM watsonx, ClearBid's review agent ingests vendor quote packages, extracts line-item pricing, and performs deep deterministic checks. It automatically compares bids against historical USAspending.gov data, screens vendors against SAM.gov exclusions, flags collusion indicators, and aggregates real-world online user reviews and sentiment data to evaluate vendor reliability.
- **Human-in-the-Loop Decision Dashboard:** Recognizing that AI should recommend rather than decide, ClearBid empowers procurement officers with a streamlined decision console. Officers review every AI-flagged risk, with the explicit ability to accept or override flags. Crucially, if an officer deviates from the AI's top recommendation or selects a vendor with acknowledged risk flags, they are legally required to provide a written justification.
- **Public Transparency Portal:** Once an officer awards a contract, ClearBid automatically generates a plain-language citizen summary. Published data highlights whether the officer followed the AI recommendation or exercised an override, making the complete rationale publicly accessible while protecting sensitive vendor bank details.

By combining the scalable reasoning power of IBM watsonx with strict human-in-the-loop governance, ClearBid transforms opaque procurement into a fast, fraud-resistant, and entirely transparent public service.